sporting heroics. It was almost as if we needed to set up an environment where I was totally safe, judgement-free, for me to let go of caution and see where thought and speech took me.

When she wasn't doing that, my dad would sit at the end of my bed and watch late-night American football with me while I tried to do my maths homework. It was quite nice, that time difference, and watching a sport on the other side of the world. He did not know that, in years to come, he would again receive that translucent glow through the night, setting his alarm to watch me play day after day, series after series, of Ashes cricket in Australia. Back then we'd watch until I caught a sight of Dan Marino, the Miami Dolphins quarterback, and then, when Dad realised I wasn't going to take my eyes off the game, he'd finish my homework while I watched Marino make plays. I liked Marino because, being the quarterback, everything ran through him. He was the centre of every single play. The game did not start until he started. He read plays; he sidestepped tackles; he saw things other people didn't see. When he turned up not long after in *Ace Ventura: Pet Detective*, his legendary status in my mind was forever confirmed.

The thing I didn't really envy about Dan Marino was the bodies flying at him constantly, looking like they were trying to decapitate him. It was the only undesirable thing about doing what he did and a suspicion I had confirmed when I was a teenager and was asked to play rugby for the club. They'd seen me play other sports and thought, given I was quite fast, that I would be a useful winger in the last ten minutes. I am a substitute and watch in fear as 16-stone teenagers absolutely mash each other up. My first piece of action is having a Jonah Lomu-type player running at me. He is the size of buildings. I stick my arm out and he runs through me like a turnstile. Later on in the game, I get the ball on the wing and do what I've been told – I ran as fast as I can to the try line. I brace for impact, race off and, incredibly, feel no one get near me to begin with. As I see the line getting closer, hoovering it towards me, flailing chunky arms in my peripheries and hearing a stampede in my wake, I forget to take heed of Burnley's classically unsteady playing grounds. There is a little crater that my foot goes through and, on impact, my legs just buckle completely. I admit defeat and do not clamber back directly to my feet. In the second I'm lying there, waiting for oceans of boys much bigger than me to throw their whole